in short supply. Here, in the middle of cultivated land is a horizontal ledge in the rocky outcrop which was used for the engraving. A large boulder hangs over the ledge and seems almost to have squeezed the space between it and the inscribed surface. Interestingly, this part of the knoll faces the Brahmagiri hill and not Jatinga-Rameshwara. Was the Siddapura slab's orientation merely functional, in that it was perhaps the best surface available for putting down a message running into twenty-two lines, even if the restricted space above it made the business of reading it difficult? Alternatively, were the Brahmagiri and Siddapura rocks places where local festivities or rituals had been established and which the administration hoped could be redeployed for the new message? Were the emperor's edicts actually seen regularly, as they were in the nineteenth century, only because local cattle-keepers and goatherds used shady overhanging rocky eaves as protection against the hot summer sun? At the point in time when Ashoka's inscription was discovered, Siddapura's low hilly landscape bore a name that suggested such links. It was called 'Yenamana timmayyana gundlu', or 'the buffalo-herd Timmayya's rocks'.[45] Which of these is the best explanation, and whether other deductions lurk are matters for unending speculation because, as at Maski, no specific archaeological pointers can guide enquiry. But there is every reason to imagine that all who came to Siddapura—devotees, shepherds, local children, lovers in search of privacy—could not have failed to note a Buddhist emperor's presence looming larger than life in their lived landscape.

If at Brahmagiri and Siddapura the edicts were inscribed around the base areas of the rocky ridge, at Jatinga-Rameshwara, the third point in this cluster, they happened to be located on a high hill some distance from the surrounding town and villages. Some similarities link the Jatinga-Rameshwara edict with the other two locations. As there, the writing is cut into a slanting horizontal rock face and has a large boulder overhanging it. It is likely that the same group of officials located the appropriate rocks